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**LINCOLN'S
GREATEST SPEECH**

THE SECOND INAUGURAL

RONALD C. WHITE JR.

"In lucid prose, White explores each level and places the Second Inaugural in a broad historical and theological context." —JAMES M. McPHERSON

A NEW YORK TIMES NOTABLE BOOK

ABRAHAM LINCOLN

Second Inaugural Address¹

[Fellow Countrymen:]

March 4, 1865

At this second appearing to take the oath of the presidential office, there is less occasion for an extended address than there was at the first. Then a statement, somewhat in detail, of a course to be pursued, seemed fitting and proper. Now, at the expiration of four years, during which public declarations have been constantly called forth on every point and phase of the great contest which still absorbs the attention, and engrosses the energies [*sic*] of the nation, little that is new could be presented. The progress of our arms, upon which all else chiefly depends, is as well known to the public as to myself; and it is, I trust, reasonably satisfactory and encouraging to all. With high hope for the future, no prediction in regard to it is ventured.

On the occasion corresponding to this four years ago, all thoughts were anxiously directed to an impending civil-war. All dreaded it—all sought to avert it. While the inaugural address was being delivered from this place, devoted altogether to *saving* the Union without war, insurgent agents were in the city seeking to *destroy* it without war—seeking to dissol[v]e the Union, and divide effects, by negotiation. Both parties deprecated war; but one of them would *make* war rather than let the nation survive; and the other would *accept* war rather than let it perish. And the war came.

One eighth of the whole population were colored slaves, not distributed generally over the Union, but localized in the Southern part² of it. These slaves constituted a peculiar and powerful interest. All knew that this interest was, somehow, the cause of the war. To strengthen, perpetuate, and extend this interest was the object for which the insurgents would rend the Union, even by war; while the government claimed no right to do more than to restrict the territorial enlargement of it. Neither party expected for the war, the magnitude, or the duration, which it has already

attained. Neither anticipated that the *cause* of the conflict might cease with, or even before, the conflict itself should cease. Each looked for an easier triumph, and a result less fundamental and astounding. Both read the same Bible, and pray to the same God; and each invokes His aid against the other. It may seem strange that any men should dare to ask a just God's assistance in wringing their bread from the sweat of other men's faces; but let us judge not that we be not judged. The prayers of both could not be answered; that of neither has been answered fully. [The Almighty has His own purposes. "Woe unto the world because of offences! for it must needs be that offences come; but woe to that man by whom the offence cometh!" If we shall suppose that American Slavery is one of those offences which, in the providence of God, must needs come, but which, having continued through His appointed time, He now wills to remove, and that He gives to both North and South, this terrible war, as the woe due to those by whom the offence came, shall we discern therein any departure from those divine attributes which the believers in a Living God always ascribe to Him? Fondly do we hope—ferently do we pray—that this mighty scourge of war may speedily pass away. Yet, if God wills that it continue, until all the wealth piled by the bond-man's two hundred and fifty years of unrequited toil shall be sunk, and until every drop of blood drawn with the lash, shall be paid by another drawn with the sword, as was said three³ thousand years ago, so still it must be said "the judgments of the Lord, are true and righteous altogether"]

With malice toward none; with charity for all; with firmness in the right, as God gives us to see the right, let us strive on to finish the work we are in; to bind up the nation's wounds; to care for him who shall have borne the battle, and for his widow, and his orphan—to do all which may achieve and cherish a just, and a lasting peace, among ourselves, and with all nations.⁴

[Endorsement]

Original manuscript of second Inaugural presented to Major John Hay.

A. LINCOLN

April 10. 1865

9

“... better than anything I have produced, but... it is not immediately popular.”

As Lincoln concluded his Second Inaugural Address, people were still arriving. He had spoken for only six to seven minutes. After a brief silence at the end of the address, artillery combined with cannonades of applause from the crowd. Lincoln bowed in acknowledgment of their acclamation.

Chief Justice Salmon P. Chase stepped forward. At that time, the oath was administered after the presidential address. At Lincoln's first inaugural, the chief justice had been the aged Roger Taney, forever to be identified with the Dred Scott Decision of 1857, which reaffirmed that slaves were property and that Congress was obliged to protect that property. Chase had been elevated to the office of chief justice by Lincoln. On this day, when irony would be heaped upon irony, the man who had sought to displace Lincoln as the candidate of the Republican Party in 1864 would administer the presidential oath of office.

Chase gestured to the clerk of the Supreme Court, who handed him a Bible. George Washington, who brought his own Bible to his first inauguration, had initiated this part of the ceremony. Lincoln placed his right hand on the page of the Bible open to Isaiah 5. Chase asked Lincoln to swear

upon the Bible. Lincoln repeated the presidential oath after the chief justice.

Lincoln ended with an emphatic “So help me God.” He bent down and kissed the Bible. The dignity and solemnity of the scene were in stark contrast to Vice-President Johnson's earlier unseemly demeanor. The inauguration was completed at seventeen minutes past twelve o'clock.¹

Chief Justice Chase presented the Bible to Mrs. Lincoln. He pointed to the pencil-marked verses from Isaiah kissed by the president.

None shall be weary nor stumble among them;
none shall slumber nor sleep;
Neither shall the girdle of their loins be loosed,
nor the latchet of their shoes be broken.
Whose arrows are sharp,
And all their bows bent,
their horses' hoofs shall be counted like flint,
and their wheels like a whirlwind.

[Isaiah 5:27–28, KJV]

Lincoln left the portico and went directly to the basement entrance of the Capitol, where his carriage awaited him. The president, with his young son Tad scrambling to get in at his side, was driven back to the White House. The houses along the route were lined with admirers waving handkerchiefs from windows and rooftops. Sharpshooters were plainly visible from many buildings. John Wilkes Booth sauntered back along the avenue.

How did the inaugural audience respond to the address? Fortunately, the correspondent for the *New York Herald* re-

ported their reactions in detail. We are told that Lincoln's entire address produced only intermittent applause from the large audience, but for one notable exception. African Americans in the crowd offered a steady "bress de Lord" at the end of almost every sentence.²

Lincoln paused after the fourth sentence in the first paragraph,

The progress of our arms, upon which all else chiefly depends, is as well known to the public as to myself; and it is, I trust, reasonably satisfactory and encouraging to all.

The *New York Herald* writer believed Lincoln expected a response. There was none.

The first cheer followed the next-to-last sentence of the second paragraph, when Lincoln declared, "*Both parties deprecated war; but one of them would make war rather than let the nation survive; and the other would accept war rather than let it perish.*" The crowd did applaud when Lincoln, speaking about slavery at the beginning of the third paragraph, stated, "*All knew that this interest was, somehow, the cause of the war.*" The *New York Herald* correspondent reported Lincoln's words from later in the third paragraph, "*It may seem strange that any men should dare to ask a just God's assistance in wringing their bread from the sweat of other men's faces,*" as a "satirical observation" which "caused a half laugh" from the audience.³

At that point, the address was less than half over. Remarkably, there would be no more audible response, apart from the steady "bress de Lord," for the almost four hundred words that remained in the address. Today, we are accustomed to having inaugural addresses interrupted by frequent applause. The reporter remarked that these few reactions "were the only marks of approbation until the close of the

address." The reporter's puzzlement in his reporting of the audience's response is evident.⁴

In the ensuing days, men got together around cracker barrels in grocery stores in hundreds of towns to discuss what "Old Abe" had said in Washington. Women spoke across back gardens to offer their opinions of the president's words.

Early the next morning, Sunday, March 5, at 3 A.M., the Western Union finally connected the telegraph wires from New York to San Francisco. This achievement was hailed as opening up a direct and almost instant communication never before possible. Four years before, in March 1861, riders of the Pony Express had stuffed copies of Lincoln's First Inaugural into their saddle bags as they rode across plains and mountains to deliver the new president's words to Sacramento. Now, in March 1865, newspapers took advantage of this new link to print the text of the address, delaying editorial comment until the next edition. As the address was flashed by telegraph to newspapers across the country, ordinary citizens on farms, and in towns and cities around the nation, responded to what Lincoln had said and not said. Their reactions captured a remarkably mixed response.

One Pennsylvanian wrote his complaint to Simon Cameron, Lincoln's first secretary of war. "Lincoln's Inaugural, while the sentiments are noble, is one of the most awkwardly expressed documents I have ever read." A. B. Bradford added, "When he knew it would be read by millions all over the world, why under the heavens did he not make it a little more creditable to American scholarship." Perhaps Bradford knew of Seward's help with the First Inaugural, for now he wondered, "Why could not Mr. Seward have prepared the Inaugural so as to save it from the ridicule of a Sophomore in a British University."⁵

Frederick Douglass was an astute observer of the meaning of both the event and the address. "The whole proceeding was wonderfully quiet, earnest, and solemn." He agreed with the observations of the reporter for the *New York Herald*, but went further in describing the mood: "There was a leaden stillness about the crowd." He believed he knew why. "The address sounded more like a sermon than a state paper." Reflecting on Lincoln's words, Douglass said that he "clapped my hands in gladness and thanksgiving at their utterance." But when he looked around, he "saw in the faces of many about me expressions of widely different emotion."

Young Charles Francis Adams, Jr., was in the crowd that day. Adams counted two presidents, John Adams and John Quincy Adams, in his lineage. His father, Charles Francis Adams, had served as minister to England since 1861, deserving much credit for keeping England neutral during the Civil War. Young Adams had been commissioned as first lieutenant in the 1st Massachusetts Cavalry. His regiment fought at Antietam and Gettysburg. In July 1864, Adams had been given a lieutenant colonel's commission in the 5th Massachusetts Cavalry, an African-American regiment. He had been promoted to colonel in early 1865. Now he found himself in Washington, determined to witness Lincoln's second inauguration.

The twenty-nine-year-old Adams wrote to his father in London on Tuesday, March 7, "What do you think of the inaugural?," then offered his own estimation: "That rail-splitting lawyer is one of the wonders of the day. Once at Gettysburg and now again on a greater occasion he has shown a capacity for rising to the demands of the hour." Adams concluded, "This inaugural strikes me in its grand simplicity and directness as being for all time the historical keynote of this war."⁸

Lincoln's audience, even when standing in the same location, facing the west wing of the Capitol, was really standing in many different locations. Their social and political locations had much to do with how they heard the speech. Charles Francis Adams, Jr., age twenty-nine, and John Wilkes Booth, age twenty-six, young white men, stood in radically different political locations.

Listeners and readers responded differently. By far the largest response was to the first words of Lincoln's final paragraph, "*With malice toward none; with charity for all.*" Those words were picked up immediately after the address in newspaper accounts and editorials. They were quickly fashioned upon badges, medals, and ribbons. After Lincoln's assassination, when there was a great outpouring of affection for the slain president, these words were frequently quoted.

Another response focused on Lincoln's words about slavery. Shortly after the Second Inaugural, Mrs. Amanda H. Hall wrote a letter to her brother, Thomas W. Ferry, a member of the House of Representatives from Michigan. Congressman Ferry showed the letter to Lincoln.

Lincoln, "induced by a letter of yours to your brother," wrote to Mrs. Hall on March 20, transcribing in his own hand these words from the Second Inaugural.

*Fondly do we hope—fervently do we pray—that this mighty scourge of war may speedily pass away. Yet, if God wills that it continue, until all the wealth piled by the bond-man's two hundred and fifty years of unrequited toil shall be sunk, and until every drop of blood drawn with the lash, shall be paid by another drawn with the sword, as was said three thousand years ago, so still it must be said "the judgments of the Lord, are true and righteous altogether[.]"*⁹

Mrs. Hall was drawn to the same passage that captured Frederick Douglass. Almost immediately, many facsimiles of Lincoln's words to her were produced. Years later, many owners believed that they had the original letter from Lincoln, because the facsimiles had the appearance of the original.¹⁰

Of course American newspapers weighed in with their responses. There had been an explosion of newspapers in the nineteenth century. In 1800, there were approximately 250 newspapers. By 1860, there were more than twenty-five hundred, both daily and weekly, more newspapers than the rest of the world combined. Some people read two, three, or four newspapers a day in their hunger to encounter a world beyond the farm, village, or small town.

As political participation increased with the growth of political parties, most newspapers became highly partisan. Their editorials and reporting reflected their respective positions. In large and even smaller cities one found newspapers with opposite political points of view.

During the Civil War, newspapers in the major cities conflicted dramatically regarding Lincoln as president. The *New York Times* and the *New York World* disagreed about Lincoln, the war, and slavery. The *Chicago Tribune* and the *Chicago Times* could be expected to take opposite positions on Lincoln, the Emancipation Proclamation, and the Second Inaugural Address. In Cincinnati, the *Daily Commercial* was pro-Lincoln, whereas the *Cincinnati Enquirer* was anti-Lincoln.¹¹

To experience this divided attitude was nothing new for Lincoln. In his hometown of Springfield, the *Sangamo Journal*, which became the *Illinois Daily State Journal*, was unswerving in its support. Editor Edward L. Baker led the way in fighting "the fire in the rear," the opposition to the

war in portions of the Northwest. On the other hand, the *Daily Illinois State Register*, the Democratic newspaper in Springfield, criticized Lincoln throughout his career. Editor Charles H. Lanphier, a Virginian, did not like one thing about Lincoln. He promoted the charge that Lincoln was a joker and not a thinker. When Lanphier left the paper in November 1863, the *Register* continued to smear Lincoln.¹²

Lincoln made the newspaper his political platform. He spoke about the power of printing in a lecture on "Discovery and Inventions" delivered in several places in Illinois in the winter of 1859. He offered his opinion on "certain inventions and discoveries" that were "of peculiar value" because "of their efficiency in facilitating all other inventions and discoveries." Although prizing speaking and writing, Lincoln especially trumpeted printing, which "gave ten thousand copies of any written matter, quite as cheaply as ten were given before." Lincoln homed in on the value of printing. "Consequently a thousand minds were brought into the field where there was but one before." He welcomed the interchange that newspapers promoted.¹³

The major players in the press and in politics were often the same persons. Henry J. Raymond, publisher of the *New York Times*, was chairman of the Republican National Committee and a Lincoln confidant. The *New York World* was established as a Republican newspaper in 1860, but it foundered under mismanagement and was taken over by Mayor Fernando Wood of New York City and August Belmont, a leading banker. Both were Democrats hostile to Lincoln. Under the direction of the young editor Manton Marble, the *World* led the radical opposition to Lincoln during the war. Yet another politician, Democratic Congressman Benjamin Wood, owned the *Daily News* in New York and used it to make mischief for Lincoln.¹⁴

No one would have been more interested in the response of the newspapers to the Second Inaugural than Lincoln himself. He had been fascinated by newspapers his whole life. When he was the postmaster in the village of New Salem, Lincoln read the newspapers before handing them out. In 1832, Lincoln announced his first candidacy for the Illinois Assembly through the *Sangamo Journal*, a staunchly Whig newspaper. After entering politics in the 1830s, he reported on the Illinois legislature for the *Sangamo Journal*. He liked to hang out at the newspaper shop. He signed up subscribers. He liked to spend his evenings at the newspaper's city room, helping his friend Baker, the editor, a graduate of Harvard Law School, with editorials. Lincoln even wrote letters to the editor under assumed names.

As president, Lincoln was known to have stepped outside the White House to ask a person walking by to send a corner newsboy to his front door with the latest newspaper. His law partner, Herndon, reported that what Lincoln chiefly read was newspapers. He continued to read newspapers in the White House, although "peruse" might be the better word for a president who was also the commander-in-chief, working long hours every day. In Lincoln's study in the White House there were usually three Washington newspapers: the *Daily Morning Chronicle*, the *National Republican*, and the *Evening Star*. Many editors sent their newspapers to Lincoln in hopes that he would read their editorials. John Nicolay and John Hay, Lincoln's secretaries, read countless newspapers and reported to their boss what they read.

Lincoln was appreciative yet wary of newspapers. Both newspaper editors and ministers were the targets of some of his best and most biting humor. Invited to inspect a newly invented repeating gun, the chief feature being a design to pre-

vent the escape of gas, Lincoln remarked, "Well, I do believe this really does what it is represented to do. Now have any of you heard of any machine, or invention, for preventing the escape of gas from newspaper offices?"¹⁵

From no source did Lincoln receive more gas than from the "newspaper generals" of the North. They were free with advice and quick with criticism, from the opening crisis at Fort Sumter through the emancipation debate to discussion of terms for ending the war. The "newspaper generals" were headquartered in New York: Henry J. Raymond of the *New York Times*, James Gordon Bennett of the *New York Herald*, and Horace Greeley of the *New York Tribune*. The *Times* was strongly Republican. The *Herald*, with the largest circulation in the United States—probably over 130,000—was Democratic and began the war with a pro-Southern posture. It also sold its newspapers in Europe and thus was in a position to influence European thought about the conflict. Horace Greeley was no admirer of Lincoln while the president lived. Greeley said in August 1864 that Lincoln was already beaten, though he changed his tune in the fall and supported Lincoln's re-election. How would the newspaper generals and editors respond to Lincoln's Second Inaugural?

The responses of the leading newspapers, even after placing them on the political map, offer some surprises. The usually friendly *New York Times* expressed its disappointment. The *Times* surely spoke for many in complaining, "He makes no boasts of what he has done, or promises of what he will do. He does not reexpound the principles of the war; does not redeclare the worth of the Union; does not reproclaim that absolute submission to the Constitution is the only peace." The best praise the *New York Times* could offer was simply, "All that he does is simply to advert to the cause of the war;

and its amazing development; to recognize in the solemn language the righteous judgment of Heaven; and to drop an earnest exhortation that all will now stand by the right and strive for a peace that shall be just and lasting."¹⁶ The *New York Times*, a supporter of Lincoln, was not very impressed.

The *New York Herald* was "disappointed" that Lincoln had said nothing about the recent Hampton Roads Peace Conference, for it "would have gratified loyal states." The *Herald* was even more disappointed in Lincoln's "silence" about such important topics as the Mexican question, Napoleon, Maximilian, and the Monroe Doctrine, to say nothing of the entire Baltimore Platform, "on which he was re-elected." The *Herald* opined, "Its main topic was slavery as the war cause." Lincoln accepted the war "as God punishing the nation for the 'offence' of slavery." Because Lincoln did not mention the Thirteenth Amendment, whose purpose was to abolish slavery by law, the *Herald* concluded that in the end Lincoln was solely dependent on the sword to abolish slavery. In this spirit the *Herald* reporter argued with Lincoln's peroration by stating that the intention to destroy slavery "contradicts Abraham Lincoln's call to 'charity for all.'"¹⁷

The *Herald* editorial had little good to say about the Second Inaugural, which it called "a little speech of 'glittering generalities' used only to fill in the program." It deemed Lincoln's remarks "not up to the mark of Napoleon's last imperial speech." Finally, the *Herald* complained that "the Second Inaugural address was an effort to avoid any commitment regarding our domestic or foreign affairs."¹⁸

The *World* editorial made the *Herald* look tame. "It is with a blush of shame and wounded pride, as American citizens, that we lay before our readers to-day the inaugural addresses of President Lincoln and Vice-President Johnson. But we cannot hide the dishonor done to the country we love by withholding these documents from publication." The *World*

found Lincoln's words completely wanting, compared with what was needed at this hour of crisis. "The pity of it, that a divided nation should neither be sustained in this crisis of agony by words of wisdom nor cheered with words of hope."¹⁹

The *Chicago Times*, under editor Wilbur Fiske Storey, had opposed all forms of emancipation. As a copperhead or peace Democrat, Storey broke with Lincoln when the emancipation plan was first announced, in September 1862. The *Times* now offered this opinion of the Second Inaugural: "We did not conceive it possible that even Mr. Lincoln could produce a paper so slip shod, so loose-jointed, so puerile, not alone in literary construction, but in its ideas, its sentiments, its grasp."²⁰

In Lincoln's hometown of Springfield, readers had long been accustomed to harangues from the *Daily Illinois State Register*. The editorial of March 8, under the title "Biblical Acumen and Presidential Prophecy," stated that the Second Inaugural was "not a very felicitous nor satisfactory performance." Declaring that many topics "were pressing upon public importance," the editorial complained, "our revered president should have neither time nor impulse to devote to them a moment's consideration." The *Register* acknowledged "our good opinion of his biblical learning," but used this applause as the opportunity to indict Lincoln: "He does not hesitate to pray into the arcana of God's council."²¹

The Philadelphia newspapers had put their trust in the president throughout his entire first term. All were Republican except the *Evening Journal*. Publisher Jesper Harding of the *Philadelphia Inquirer* had criticized the armchair generals of the New York press for their constant criticism of Lincoln. Harding had consistently backed the president's patient handling of the war.

It was no surprise that the *Philadelphia Inquirer's* response

to the Second Inaugural diverged from the opinion of the New York newspapers. "The address is characteristic of Mr. Lincoln. It exhibits afresh the kindness of his heart, and the large charity which has ever marked his actions toward those who are his personal enemies as well as enemies of his country."²²

The *Washington (D.C.) Daily National Intelligencer* had been only lukewarm in its support of his administration under the editorship of William W. Seaton, an aging Virginian. Only months before Lincoln's second inauguration, there had been a change of ownership and an abrupt change of policy toward support for Lincoln. The *Intelligencer* concluded its editorial with acclaim for the words of the final paragraph. "They are equally distinguished for patriotism, statesmanship, and benevolence, and deserve to be printed in gold."²³

The *Jersey City Times* believed the address might yet convert some of Lincoln's critics. "It will stand forever as an announcement, grand in its simplicity, and unflexible in its resolve, of the faith of the American people in the stability of their free government and the justice and invincibility of their cause." The ultimate praise was due the author of the address. "It will make thousands say, who have not hitherto said, 'God bless Abraham Lincoln.'"²⁴ The editorial predicted that the address would take its place in history.

In the South, Lincoln's Second Inaugural offered particular problems. The motto of the Confederacy, *Deo vindice* (God will avenge), spoke to the South's self-identity as a Christian nation. Southerners were keenly aware that their Confederate Constitution, unlike the silence of the federal Constitution, included "invoking the favor and guidance of Almighty God." Throughout the war, Southern politicians and pastors had comforted themselves that they were the true Christian people, as contrasted with the North, which they charged

had been corrupted by liberalizing movements in theology and non-Christian immigrants. What, then, to make of Lincoln's Biblical words and theological language?

Only a few newspapers in the South offered their opinions of the Second Inaugural. By the spring of 1865, only twenty-two newspapers were still publishing in the South. The five newspapers in Richmond reached an audience far beyond the boundaries of the capital of the Confederacy. Those newspapers generally blended piety with politics. The exception was the *Richmond Examiner*, which by the middle of 1862 had begun to complain that no amount of piety could take the place of manly honor and moral courage. Editor John Moncure Daniel began to stress a secular "patriotism" different from what was espoused by most other newspapers in the South. The *Richmond Examiner* was not hospitable, therefore, to Lincoln's combining politics and religion in the Second Inaugural. "It reads like the tail of some old sermon, and seems to have no particular meaning of any kind, at least, if any meaning lurks in it we fail to perceive it."²⁵

The Second Inaugural occurred just at the moment when Grant was besieging Petersburg, Virginia, on his way toward Richmond. The *Daily Express* of Petersburg had not taken the tack of the *Richmond Examiner* concerning the place of religion in the Confederacy. One hears in the editorial of March 9 puzzlement about Lincoln's words. "His allusions to Almighty Power and his citations from the scriptures might well become a Preacher of Righteousness. He seems to be thoroughly imbued with reverence for the Gospel of peace and with faith in Divine revelations." The writer was puzzled by Lincoln's words as evidenced in his conclusion. "We will refrain from expressing our opinion, saying with Lincoln, who borrowed the idea and most of the words from our Savior's Sermon on the Mount: 'Let us judge not, that we be not judged.'"²⁶

Many of the newspapers noticed the unusual feature of the theological content of the address. The *Washington Daily National Intelligencer*, a new supporter of Lincoln, commented that, by invoking "religious views," Lincoln was likely to run afoul of those who advocated a strict separation of church and state in public discourse. Thus, in their prediction of response to the address, the *Intelligencer* stated that Lincoln might be subject "to that sort of criticism" by the press.²⁷

The *Intelligencer* was on the mark. The *New York World* made an attack on Lincoln's use of religion the heart of its assault, comparing Lincoln's remarks to a late encyclical letter by Pope Pius IX. The *World* disparaged the Pope's intention of subordinating secular rule to spiritual authority as an attempt to replace the politics of the nineteenth century with the politics of the Middle Ages. However absurd in the eyes of the *World*, the Pope's words were at least intelligible. Not so Lincoln's intention or words. "The President's theology smacks as strong of the dark ages as does Pope Pius IX's politics." Arguing with Lincoln's premise about the "offence" of slavery, the *World* stated, "Mr. Lincoln expects our cause to succeed by the prevailing efficacy of our prayers when we are to hold up the negro to heaven as a token of our penitence for other men's sins." The editor certainly missed Lincoln's emphasis on the inclusivity of the nation's sins. Finally, the *World* indicted Lincoln for "abandoning all pretense of statesmanship . . . in this strange inaugural" by taking "refuge in piety."²⁸

Lincoln's address was reviewed in London and in some of the other capitals of Europe. English newspapers, many of which had supported the Confederacy for much of the war, offered

thoughtful comment. The *Times* of London, with a record of four years of pro-Confederate editorials, stated, "This short Inaugural speech reveals Abraham Lincoln's disposition and opinions more completely than many verbose compositions of his predecessors." The *Times* correspondent appreciated that Lincoln spoke "without any feeling of exhilaration at success or sanguine anticipation of coming prosperity."²⁹

The London *Spectator* was eloquent in its praise of both Lincoln's character and the address. "Mr. Lincoln has persevered through all without ever giving way to anger, or despondency, or exultation, or popular arrogance, or sectarian fanaticism, or caste prejudice, visibly growing in force of character, in self-possession, and in magnanimity." The *Spectator* recalled that in 1861 the "village attorney" was scorned in England. Now "we can detect no longer the rude and illiterate mould of a village lawyer's thought, but find it replaced by a grasp of principle, a dignity of manner, and a solemnity of purpose which would have been unworthy neither of Hampden nor of Cromwell, while his gentleness and generosity of feeling towards his foes are almost greater than we should expect from either of them." The *Spectator*, using Biblical imagery, opined that Lincoln "seems destined to be one of those 'foolish things of the world' which are destined to confound the wise, one of those weak things which shall 'confound the things which are mighty.'"³⁰

The *Saturday Review* began by contrasting Lincoln with the usual posture it had come to expect from its American cousin. "If it had been composed by any other prominent American politician, it would have been boastful, confident, and menacing." The *Saturday Review* found, "His unshaken purpose of continuing the war until it ends in victory assumes the form of resigned submission to the inscrutable decrees of a superior Power."³¹

John Bigelow, an officer at the United States Legation in Paris, wrote to Secretary of State Seward to report on the French response. "The President's inaugural has enjoyed a rare distinction for an American state paper of being correctly translated and almost universally copied here." Bigelow offered his opinion as to why the address was so well received. Its success was "less due to its brevity than to its almost inspired simplicity and Christian dignity." Bigelow sent along an article from the *Opinion Nationale* as an example of this kind of commendation.³²

A reporter for the *Chicago Tribune* cabled a similar response from Paris on March 21. "The message of President Lincoln . . . has been received here with unmitigated satisfaction, its moderation of tone, its wise reticence with respect to the war, the absence of all boasting either as regards the glorious past or the hopeful future, its truthfulness, simplicity and reverential character" contributing to "the reception and respectful attention it so well deserves." This writer focused on the closing words of the final paragraph, usually overlooked by American newspapers.

. . . and a lasting peace, among ourselves, and with all nations.

As an American correspondent in Paris, the *Chicago Tribune* writer said he had been "pestered" by many inquiries of what would happen when the war was over and "the American Union once more restored to its full strength." Many in France were worried in the spring of 1865 that the end of the war could be followed quickly by "the appearance of an American fleet of ironclads in the port of Havre, or a fleet of

gunboats sailing up the Seine to take Paris!" It was in this context that the French public, both political and commercial, responded so positively to Lincoln's "concluding words of peace and good will to all nations."³³

A most important commentator was the president himself. Lincoln expressed himself in a response to Thurlow Weed, the New York Republican boss who wrote him on that same March 4. Weed had written to commend Lincoln's March 2 reply to the Committee of Congress's notification to the president of his re-election. Weed had also mentioned the second inauguration earlier that day. Lincoln evidently misconstrued Weed's commendation as kind words about both "my little notification speech" and the inaugural address.

Lincoln answered Weed eleven days later, on March 15, offering his thoughts about his Second Inaugural. "I expect the latter to wear as well—perhaps better than anything I have produced." Lincoln then adds a fascinating caveat that reveals much about his own perception: "but I believe it is not immediately popular."³⁴

What did Lincoln mean about the address's not being "immediately popular"? He had read a variety of newspapers, as he always did, and so had read the mixed reviews and editorial comment. I think he had considered the risk in preparing his Second Inaugural, and understood before he delivered it that it would disappoint many people for various reasons. He surely knew that most people expected him to talk about policy and plans. Others might be put off by his extensive quotations from the Bible and his use of theological arguments and language. But the Whig and now the Republican parties had always tried to seize the religious high ground in their approach to politics.

Lincoln supplied his own answer. "Men are not flattered

by being shown that there has been a difference of purpose between the Almighty and them." Human purpose, whether of the North or the South, lay in the invoking of a tribal God. His purpose had been to invoke a universal God. He had dared to say that this God was judging the whole nation for the "offence" of slavery. With God there is no partiality.

The issue was, finally, one of purpose. "To deny it, however, in this case, is to deny that there is a God governing the world." He had pondered God's purpose in the "Meditation on the Divine Will" and come to the conclusion, "In the present civil war it is quite possible that God's purpose is something different from the purpose of either party." In his first letter to Eliza Gurney, he had linked this purpose to God's governing in the world. "We must believe that He permits it [the war] for some wise purpose of his own, mysterious and unknown to us; and though with our limited understandings we may not be able to comprehend it, yet we cannot but believe, that he who made the world still governs it."³⁵

Lincoln's comments to Weed illuminate his own understanding of the text. His words underscore that in his mind the central theme of the address was "*The Almighty has His own purposes*." His beliefs had unquestionably moved far beyond any doctrine of necessity or environmental determinism.

Two thousand people crowded the streets outside the White House waiting for the inaugural reception. At eight o'clock, the gates were opened and the free-for-all began. Maggie Lindsley and her family attempted to attend the White House reception but could not even get inside the gates, "so great was the crowd!" William H. Crook, Lincoln's bodyguard, observed, "The White House looked as if a regiment of rebel troops had been quartered there—with permission to forage." In the East Room, Lincoln, looking slightly ill, pre-

pared to shake the hands of the more than six thousand people who crowded the reception.³⁶

One person in the afternoon audience was determined to attend the inauguration reception that evening at the White House. Arriving at 1600 Pennsylvania Avenue, Frederick Douglass found himself barred at the door by two policemen. When he protested, they informed him that their "directions were to admit no one of color." Douglass quickly replied that there must be some mistake, for "no such order could have emanated from President Lincoln." Whether there were any directions from anyone, or whether they were simply following precedent, we do not know. Perhaps to end the confrontation, which was blocking the entrance, one of the officers offered to escort Douglass in. Before long, however, Douglass found himself being escorted out a window that had been set up as a temporary exit because there were so many visitors. Douglass saw the trick and asked a passing guest to tell Mr. Lincoln that he was being detained. The appeal reached the president.

All of the handshaking stopped as Douglass entered the East Room. As he approached, Lincoln called out, "Here comes my friend Douglass." Douglass was certain that Lincoln's greeting was said in such a voice "that all around could hear him." Taking Douglass by the hand, the president said, "I am glad to see you. I saw you in the crowd today, listening to my inaugural address; how did you like it?"

Douglass responded, "Mr. Lincoln, I must not detain you with my poor opinion, when there are thousands waiting to shake hands with you."

"No, no," Lincoln answered, "you must stop a little Douglass; there is no man in the country whose opinion I value more than yours. I want to know what you think of it?"

"Mr. Lincoln, that was a sacred effort," Douglass replied.³⁷

Epilogue

Forty-one days after delivering the Second Inaugural Address, Lincoln was dead.

Events moved quickly following the inauguration. In little more than a month, on April 9, 1865, Lee surrendered to Grant at Appomattox Courthouse, Virginia. The next day, official news of the surrender touched off tumultuous celebrations in Washington. On Friday, April 14, the Stars and Stripes was hoisted at Fort Sumter, four years to the day after their lowering had signaled the beginning of the war.

On the evening of April 14—Good Friday—while watching a play at Ford's Theatre, Lincoln was shot by John Wilkes Booth. He died the next day at 7:22 A.M. A stunned nation struggled to grasp the first assassination of an American president. On April 16—Easter Sunday—people in churches across the country hailed the martyred Lincoln as a savior who in his death shed his blood as an atonement for the sins of the nation.

Abraham Lincoln considered his Second Inaugural Address to be his greatest speech! With his death, the words of the Second Inaugural quickly took on new meaning. It now represented the central part of Lincoln's unfinished legacy. As people looked back to that brisk March day, Lincoln's words

were understood as his last will and testament to America. The religious cast of the Second Inaugural gave it a power and authority that were singular. The address would be printed in various forms. His concluding words, "*With malice toward none; with charity for all,*" usually disembodied from the speech as a whole, came to characterize Lincoln for all time.

Our focus has been on Lincoln's words. But in the end, Lincoln's rhetoric is Lincoln himself. No analysis of technique can fully explain the deep, brooding spirit that underlies his words. To trace his development as an artist is to trace his growth into greatness.

When leadership and integrity seem in short supply, Lincoln has emerged again into our national consciousness. Whereas many famous eighteenth- or nineteenth-century leaders or writers seem confined to the past, Lincoln and his words stride across the centuries with the capacity to both convict and to heal.

If Lincoln is remembered for leading the nation through war, we must not miss the battle within himself. He had prevaricated in the struggle over slavery. As president, he had been pressured and criticized by both friend and foe about the question of emancipation. Now, by the spring of 1865, he had come to some peace within himself as he looked forward to leading a nation into peace. At the Second Inaugural, not knowing he is going to die, his words sum up the life and thought of the man whom future generations esteem as the greatest American.

For too long the Second Inaugural Address has lived within the shadow of the Gettysburg Address. The Second Inaugural is paired with the Gettysburg Address in the templed space of the Lincoln Memorial. Millions upon millions of visitors have ascended the steps of the Lincoln Memorial, arrived at Daniel C. French's grand statue of Lincoln, and

turned to their right to encounter the words of Lincoln's Second Inaugural Address carved in the Indiana limestone of the North interior wall.

The spirit of Lincoln's words inspires awe. His words prove lasting because he embodied what he spoke. He acted throughout his presidency "*with malice toward none; with charity toward all.*" Still, awe is not to be confused with sentimentality.

Neither vindication nor triumphalism is present in the Second Inaugural. At the bedrock is Lincoln's humility. He included himself as one who "*looked for an easier triumph, and a result less fundamental and astounding.*" As Lincoln told Thurlow Weed on March 15, "Whatever of humiliation there is in it, falls most directly on myself."¹ We might wish that Lincoln had expanded upon this reflection, but surely he meant that he did not claim for himself moral high ground in the nation's struggle with the immorality of slavery.

The Lincoln that is available to us comes with no simple answers. The chasm of race, which undergirded the legal structure of slavery, continues even though the Civil Rights movement, a hundred years after the Civil War, spearheaded political and legal action intended to right ancient wrongs. Martin Luther King, Jr., chose to speak with the imposing statue of Lincoln as the background when he offered his dream for America.

Lincoln is present to us in his own agonizing struggle for justice and reconciliation. He encourages us to ask difficult questions as we accept responsibility for defining America in our time. Lincoln offers little comfort for those who in every crisis or war want to chant, "God is on our side."

The separation of church and state in the United States has never meant the separation of religion and politics. In words that surprised his audience, Lincoln brought to his address deep theological thinking and argument. But even as he

grounds his argument with Biblical moorings, Lincoln speaks forever against any "God bless America" theology that fails to come to terms with evil and hypocrisy in its own house. While the audience waited to hear words of self-congratulation, Lincoln continued to explain the implications of the judgment of God. He knew that the peril of theological politics is the danger of self-righteousness.

Lincoln wrote for all time. Overwhelmed by the decisions and the death toll of the Civil War, Lincoln saw that the issues at hand would not be solved by either emancipation or armistice. As the war drew to a close, Lincoln offered his sermon as the prism through which he himself strained to see the light of God. The refractions from that prism point to judgment and hope.